



▲ THE ICONIC PHOENIX HALL
AT BYŌDŌ-IN TEMPLE

Byōdō-in Temple

Location Kyoto, Japan

Originally built in 998 CE as a country villa, Byōdō-in Temple was converted into a Buddhist temple in around 1053. The focus of the complex is the elegant Phoenix Hall, added in 1053, which contains treasures of Japanese art, including a spectacular gold-coated wooden statue, almost 10 ft (3 m) tall, by the sculptor Jōchō. The distinctive wooden building itself is acknowledged as an exceptional example of architecture from the Heian period (794–1185). The Phoenix Hall comprises two symmetrical wings flanking a central hall, with a tail corridor—from the front, the overall shape, with its upturned eaves, recalls a bird with outstretched wings. Two

bronze phoenixes face each other on the rooftop. The site also features a pond and a beautiful garden.

Ancestor Temple of Foshan

Location Foshan, China

The Ancestor Temple of Foshan (or Foshan Zumiao), built in 1078–1085, during China's Northern Song dynasty (960–1126), was originally devoted to the worship of ancestors. It was rebuilt in the 14th century as a Daoist temple—dedicated to the deity Beidi (or Xuanwu), who presides over the waters—with further significant rebuilding taking place in subsequent centuries. The complex covers some 27,000 square ft (2,500 square m) and now comprises the Ancestral Temple; an early 20th-century temple devoted to China's major educator and political reformer, Confucius;

and two 21st-century temples dedicated to the martial arts. The complex contains notable carvings and sculptures and examples of Song-dynasty *dougong* (interlocking wooden roof brackets).

Ananda Temple

Location Bagan, Myanmar

Bagan's Ananda Temple—Ananda was a first cousin of the Buddha—is among the most impressive of Myanmar's Buddhist temples. Dating from the 11th or 12th century, it is dominated by its bulbous gilded spire, or *shikhar*, which rises 171 ft (52 m) from the center of the cruciform structure. Below it, on the second of the stepped terraces that support the *shikhar*, are four smaller domes at each corner of the building. The entire brick-built structure is wreathed in intricate ornamentation. Glazed terracotta plaques surround

the four principal entrances. Inside, there are two concentric corridors, in effect ambulatories, surrounding the dark space at the heart of the building, in which stand four gilded Buddhas, 30 ft (9 m) high.

Chennakeshava Temple

Location Belur, India

One of the defining features of Hindu temples as they developed across India from the 5th century onward was their profusion of sculptured decoration. Buildings seemingly shimmered in a state of permanent motion. Belur's Chennakeshava Temple, begun in 1117 on the orders of the Hoysala ruler Vishnuvardhana, is a prime example of this exuberant sculptural delight. The level of detail is such that the figures more closely resemble highly wrought metalwork